

HabitQuest - Project Context for Codex

Prepared for Iteration 1 development | Feb 17, 2026

1. One-paragraph summary

HabitQuest is a mobile-first habit and goal execution app for students and young professionals who struggle to turn big goals into daily action. The core idea is a tight accountability loop: users set a goal, break it into concrete steps/habits, check in daily, reflect (daily/weekly/monthly), and see visible progress so momentum is sustained. The app adds lightweight gamification (streaks/rewards) and an optional 'Gentle Mode' that reduces scope when burnout risk is high, helping users focus only on the most important goals without quitting entirely.

2. Problem, audience, and success criteria

Problem: Big goals stay vague; users fail to translate them into small steps, lack a daily accountability loop, progress is not visible, they lose momentum and quit - making consistent habit-building hard.

Target audience: Students and young professionals (mobile-first usage, limited time/attention, frequent schedule changes).

What 'success' means (product-level):

- A user can define a goal and see it converted into an actionable set of steps/habits.
- A user can complete a daily check-in in under 60 seconds.
- Progress is visible and motivating (streaks/progress views).
- When the user falls behind, the app helps them recover rather than quit (Gentle Mode / flexible streak handling).

3. Differentiation (must be defensible)

The market is crowded (habit trackers, to-do apps, coaching apps, gamified apps). HabitQuest differentiates on the combination below:

- **Goal -> Steps translation:** The system forces goals to become concrete, schedulable steps (size, frequency, time constraints).
- **Daily accountability loop:** Daily check-in + reflection is first-class, tied to the goal and steps (not an afterthought).
- **Gentle Mode:** A deliberate burnout-friendly mode that temporarily narrows focus to the most important goals/steps to preserve long-term consistency.
- **Progress visibility:** Simple but clear progress indicators (streaks, pace, completion history) so users can see momentum.

4. Competitive landscape (reference list)

Representative competitors and their typical strengths:

App	What they are strong at (high level)
GoalsOnTrack	SMART goals + nested subgoals, action planning tools
Strides	Multiple goal types + pacing/trajectory visualization
Habitify	Analytics-heavy tracking organized by life areas
Atoms (Atomic Habits)	Identity-based habits + habit stacking concepts
Fabulous	Behavioral-science guided routines/journeys
Streaks	Minimal daily habit streak tracker (limited tasks)
Habitica	RPG-style gamification and rewards
TickTick	Task manager + habit module + timers

HabitQuest's positioning should be communicated as: **'turn goals into daily steps with an accountability loop and burnout-friendly focus.'**

5. Core user experience (the 'loop')

The app is designed around a short repeatable loop:

- **Set Goal:** User defines a goal (title, why it matters, target date or cadence).
- **Break Down:** User creates or confirms steps/habits (small, schedulable actions).
- **Daily Check-in:** User marks steps done/not done and optionally adds a 1-line note.
- **Reflect:** Daily/weekly/monthly reflections summarize what worked and what didn't.
- **Progress:** Streaks and progress views reinforce momentum; gentle mode helps recovery after setbacks.

6. Functional requirements (build targets)

Goals

- Create/edit/archive a goal (name, description/why, optional target date).
- Goal contains one or more steps (habits or tasks).
- Goal card shows high-level progress (e.g., steps completed this week, streak).

Steps / Habits

- Create/edit/delete a step under a goal (name, frequency, optional difficulty/estimated time).
- Step has completion history (dates completed).
- Special case: step list can be empty initially; user is prompted to add at least one.

Check-in

- Daily check-in screen shows today's due steps across goals.
- User marks each step as done / skipped (or not done).
- Optional quick note: 'why' or blocker.
- Special case: missed day(s) should not hard-fail the user; show recovery UX.

Reflections

- Daily reflection prompt (very short) after check-in or end-of-day.
- Weekly/monthly reflection screens (summary + prompts).
- Special case: empty state (not enough data yet) still shows something useful.

Notifications / Reminders

- User can enable/disable reminders.
- User can set a reminder time window or specific time.
- Special case: if notification permission denied, show in-app fallback reminder messaging.

Gamification

- Streak counter for steps and/or check-ins.
- Congrats/reward screen on completion milestones (e.g., 7-day streak).

- Special case: allow flexible streak policy (e.g., one 'grace' day) or tie to Gentle Mode.

Gentle Mode (burnout-friendly)

- When enabled, user focuses on only the most important goals/steps temporarily.
- App recommends reducing scope (e.g., top 1-2 goals) based on user choice or simple signals (e.g., repeated misses).
- Clear messaging: Gentle Mode is about consistency, not failure.

7. Non-goals (explicitly out of scope for now)

- Verifying that a user actually achieved a real-world goal (no external enforcement).
- Complex social network features (sharing with friends is a 'later' idea, not Iteration 1).
- Advanced AI coaching beyond simple step suggestions (can be added later).
- Deep analytics dashboards (keep early versions simple and readable).

8. Data model (suggested minimal design)

Use a simple local-first model (can be implemented in any language/framework).

Entity	Key fields (minimum)
Goal	id, title, why/description, created_at, archived_at (nullable)
Step	id, goal_id, title, frequency (e.g., daily/3x-week), est_minutes (optional), active (bool)
CheckIn	id, date, created_at
StepCompletion	id, step_id, date, status (done/skipped), note (optional)
Reflection	id, period (daily/weekly/monthly), start_date, end_date, responses (text/json)

9. Screen list (for UI + demo planning)

- **Home / Dashboard:** goal cards, today's summary, quick check-in entry point.
- **Goal detail:** goal overview + steps list + progress history.
- **Create/Edit goal:** goal info + step breakdown flow.
- **Daily check-in:** today's steps across goals; done/skipped + quick note.
- **Reflection:** daily reflection + weekly/monthly summary screens.
- **Notifications settings:** reminder scheduling + permission handling.
- **Gentle Mode:** enable/disable + choose focus goals/steps.
- **Congrats / rewards:** streak milestones and completion acknowledgements.

10. Iteration 1 build targets (recommended)

Iteration 1 should produce a demoable slice of the core loop (not every feature). Recommended minimum:

- Create a goal + add steps (manual step entry is fine).
- Daily check-in: mark steps done and view streak.
- Basic progress view on goal card or goal detail.
- At least one special case handled (e.g., missed day recovery or empty-state step prompting).
- Clickable/demoable prototype available for classmates (if possible): deployed build, web demo, or interactive prototype.

Appendix: Notes for the Iteration 1 presentation rubric

Slides should be visual-first (full-screen screens), numbered, and include citations for any third-party assets used. The demo should show new features + special cases and be easy to follow. Screen designs

should cover planned next-iteration features, special cases, and transitions.